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Contents

Preface 7
Karol Myśliwiec, Crossing Borders 9
Olga Białostocka, Alterations to the Relief Representations of Royal Family Members' Statues in the Temple of Queen Hatshepsut at Deir el-Bahari 11
Julia Budka, The Riverbank Survey of the Humboldt University Nubian Expedition (H.U.N.E.) in Dar al-Manāṣīr: Preliminary Report for the 2004 Season 17
Federico Contardi, The Act of Reading in Ancient Egypt – Reading Aloud versus Reading Silently 29
Dorota Czerwik, "*Jnk ꜣḫ*" – in the Light of the Tomb Inscriptions from the VIth Dynasty 37
Joanna Dębowska, Tell el-Farkha Necropolis. Seasons 2001-2004 49
Eva-Maria Engel, Jochem Kahl, Die Grabanlage Djefaihapis I. in Assiut: ein Rekonstruktionsversuch 55
Massimiliano Franci, Egypto-Semitic Lexical Comparison – 2. Some considerations in the Lexicon of Physical Environment, Spontaneous Vegetation and Wild Animals 61
Aleksandra Hallmann, Was Ancient Egyptian Kohl a Poison? 69
Stefan Jakobielski, The Monastery of the Holy Trinity at Old Dongola (Sudan). Some Key Information 73
Krzysztof Jakubiak, Egyptising Lintels as a Decorative Element in Persian Architecture 89
Joanna Kociankowska-Bożek, The Meroitic Collection from Faras in National Museum in Warsaw. History of Collection 93
Edyta Kopp, A Case of a Model Letter? The Interpretation Problems with O. Berlin P. 12337 103
Peter Kopp, Waffen aus der Siedlung von Elephantine 109
Kamil Omar Kuraszkiewicz, Remarks on the Meaning of the Word *jmꜣḫw* 117
Piotr Laskowski, The Building Activity of Thutmose III at Abydos 119
Jadwiga Lipińska, Unique or Fake? 123
Tytus K. Mikołajczak, The Egyptian Influence on the Persian Winged Disk 125
Michał Neska, The Sea Peoples as a New Factor in Near Eastern and Egyptian Warfare 129
Dariusz Niedziółka, The Mysterious Structure *sjꜥr.t-mꜣꜥ.t* in the Northampton Stela of Djehuti 137
Joanna Popielska-Grzybowska, Figuratively Speaking... – the Question of the Use of Figurative Language in the Pyramid Texts 157
Mahmoud El-Tayeb & Elżbieta Kołosowska, Old Kushites and the Fourth Cataract Region 165
Mladen Tomorad, Croato-Aegyptica Electronica – Database of the Egyptian Antiquities in the Croatia Museum and Private Collections 171
Magdalena Włodarska, Development of the Saqqara Necropolis during the Ist-IIIrd Dynasties 179

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Warsaw

Figuratively Speaking... – the Question of the Use of Figurative Language in the Pyramid Texts

§ 378b *j pꜣḳ j pꜣḏ pr m mꜣst ḥrw*

"Here has the *pꜣḳ* come, here has the *pꜣḏ* come,
from the knee of Horus have issued." (spell 269 § 378 b)

For anyone who has studied ancient Egyptian culture and ancient Egyptian language hearing this excerpt of the text translation, even if understanding all of the words, having checked them carefully in the dictionaries (moreover, even if they know that *pꜣḳ* and *pꜣḏ* are terms for disk and pellet of incense), there is always the importunate thought as to what it actually means. What it really means in terms of ritual or recitation, or just any religious use. One knows it is Egyptian because of the name Horus mentioned, but "what does it mean?" This very modest example shows how important the context, the broader context of a fragment of a text, always is. Truly, though, only the so-called "Sitz im Leben" (life context) may let us approach the meaning of especially remote in time and logic writings. If one, then, reads, transaltes and consults translations of the whole spell it will appear that for example for K. Sethe,[1] L. Speleers[2] and for A. Piankoff[3] it was one spell. L. Speleers called it "Fumigation et allaitement de Roi, au cours de son voyage,"[4] and A. Piankoff: "A litany which accompanies censing. The King ascends to heaven and is assigned by Atum (the All) to the Imperishable Stars. A goddess nurses him."[5] However, for S.A.B. Mercer[6] as well as for R.O. Faulkner[7] it originally consisted of three parts. S.A.B. Mercer named it as follows: first part – "a censing text in litany form;" second part – "an asciension litany" and the third one – "an appeal by the priestly lector to the goddess 'Ipii" R.O. Faulkner also had divided it into three parts. The first part is, according to him, "A censing prayer":

§ 376a *d sḏt wbn sḏt*
§ 376b *d snṯr ḥr sḏt wbn snṯr*
§ 376c *j sṯ.k jr NN snṯr j sṯ NN jr.k snṯr*
§ 377a *j sṯ.ṯn jr NN nṯrw j sṯ NN jr.ṯn nṯrw*
§ 377b *wn NN pn ḥnꜥ.ṯn nṯrw wn.ṯn ḥnꜥ NN nṯrw*
§ 377c *ꜥnḫ NN ḥnꜥ.ṯn nṯrw ꜥnḫ.ṯn ḥnꜥ NN nṯrw*
§ 378a *mr ṯn NN nṯrw mr.(ṯn) sw nṯrw*

"The fire has been laid, the fire has appeared;
The incense has been laid on the fire, the incense has appeared.

[1] K. Sethe, *Übersetzung und Kommentar*, Glückstadt – Hamburg 1935-1939, vol. II, pp. 101-113.
[2] L. Speleers, *Traduction, Index et Vocabulaire*, Paris – Bruxelles 1934 (hereinafter referred to as: Speleers, *Traduction*), p. 56.
[3] A. Piankoff, *Pyramid of Unas*, Princeton 1968, pp. 41-42, pls. 26-27.
[4] Speleers, *Traduction*, *loc. cit*.
[5] S.A.B. Mercer, *PT in Translation and Commentary*, New York – London – Toronto 1952 (hereinafter referred to as: Mercer, *PT in Translation*), vol. II, p. 174.
[6] Mercer, *PT in Translation*, vol. I, p. 91, vol. II, pp. 174-176.
[7] R.O. Faulkner, *Egyptian Pyramid Texts*, Oxford 1969, pp. 77-78.

Your perfume has come to the King, O Incense.
May the King's perfume come to you, O Incense.
Your perfume has come to the King, gods;
May the King's perfume come to you, gods.
May this King be together with you, gods;
May you be together with the King, gods.
May the King live together with you, gods;
May you live together with the King, gods.
The King longs for you, gods;
May you long for the King, gods."

Truly we have here a classical prayer to a god or rather gods in this case, a prayer accompany censing with incense.

The second part, though, was named by Faulkner "The King ascends to the sky":

§ 378b *j pꜣḳ j pꜣḏ pr m mꜣst ḥrw*
§ 379a *j prjw j prjw j ḥfdw j ḥfdw*
§ 379b *j šwjw j šwjw*
§ 379c *pr NN* (*r.f*) *ḥr mntj jst ḥfd*(*w*) *NN ḥr mntj nbt-ḥwt*
§ 380a *nḏrw n.f jt NN tm ꜥn NN sjp.f NN*
§ 380b *n nṯrw jpf sbḳjw sꜣꜣjw j.ḫmw-sk*

"Here has the *pꜣḳ* come, here has the *pꜣḏ* come,
from the knee of Horus have issued.
Here has the mounter come, here has the mounter come!
Here has the climber come, here has the climber come!
Here has the ascender come, here has the ascender come!
The King will mount on the thighs of Isis,
The King will climb up on the thighs of Nephthys,
The King's father Atum seizes the King's hand,
And he assigns the King to those excellent and wise gods,
The Imperishable Stars."

Finally the third part "A prayer to the hippopotamus-goddess Ipy" runs as follows:

§ 381a *mjwt nt NN jpjj*
§ 381b *j.m n.f mnḏ.ṯ pw*
§ 381c *ḏꜣ n.f sw NN pn tp r.f*
§ 381d *snḳ NN jrṯt.ṯ jptw ḥḏjt sšpt bnjt*
§ 382a *tꜣ jpf j.šm NN jm.f*
§ 382b *nj jb NN jm.f nj ḥḳr NN jm.f ḏt*

"O mother of the King, Ipy, give him this breast of yours, that this King may apply it to his mouth and may suck this your white, sparkling, sweet milk. Regarding yonder land in which the King perambulates, the King will neither thirst nor hunger in it forever."

Examining the structure of this very text, one should, however, admit that it does not have to be parted. Consequently, in the beginning there is an introduction – the setting of a "story," then invocation to the gods, followed by a depiction of the person speaking (it should not be doubted that the King was to speak, one ought to note the inclusion of the dependent pronoun of the 1st person in the Pepy's text).

Would that really make any sense if we had here three separate parts, three separate prayers? The question would then come to mind: for what reason had the ancient Egyptian put them in a single spell then?

While reading such a writing one naturally, maybe even unconsciously, automatically tends to understand its language as a figurative one. It is obvious, because to our knowledge, the pharaoh as a human being cannot climb or fly up to the sky upon the thighs of goddesses. He cannot, after his death, gather his bones, etc., as some other spells suggests:

§ 735a *sḏr r.f wr pn j.bꜣn r.f*
§ 735b *j.rs NN tz tw šzp n.k tpj.k*
§ 735c *sꜣḳ n.k ḳsw.k wḫꜣ n.k ḫmw.k*

"This Great One has spent the night fast asleep. Awake, o King! Raise yourself! Receive your head, gather your bones together, shake off your dust" (spell 413 § 735 a-c)

or:

§ 364a *jb.k n.k wsjr rdwj.k n.k wsjr ꜥwj.k n.k wsjr*
§ 364b *jb n NN n.f ḏs.f rdwj.f n.f ḏs.f ꜥwj.f n.f ḏs.f*
§ 365a *sḳ.t n.f tꜣ rdw r pt pr.f jm r pt*
§ 365b *prr.f ḥr ḥtj n jdt wrt*
§ 366a *j.pꜣ NN pn m ꜣpd ḫnn.f m ḫprr*
§ 366b *j.pꜣ.f m ꜣpd ḫnn.f m ḫprr*
§ 366c *m nst šwt jmt wjꜣ.k rꜥ*
§ 367a *ꜥḥꜥ j.dr tw j.ḫm-jwt*
§ 367b *ḥms NN m st.k ḫnjj.f m pt m wjꜣ.k rꜥ*
§ 368a *jwd NN pn tꜣ m wjꜣ.k rꜥ*
§ 368b *st tw pr.k m ꜣḫt st sw ꜥbꜣ.f m ꜥ.f*
§ 368c *m sḳd wjꜣ.k rꜥ*
§ 369 *jꜥ.k n pt ḥr.k r tꜣ ḥr.t jr ḥjmt šnḏwt*

"You have your heart, Osiris; you have your legs, Osiris; you have your arms, Osiris.
The heart of the King is his own, his legs are his own, his arms are his own.
A stairway to the sky is set up for him that he may mount upon it to the sky – and he will ascend on the smoke of the great censing.
This King will fly up as a bird and alight as a beetle – he does flies up as a bird and alights as a beetle on the empty throne which is in your bark, o Ra.
Stand up, remove yourself, you who do not know the Reeds, so that the King may sit in your place and row over the sky in your bark, Ra.
This King will push off from the land in your bark, Ra. When you are coming out from the horizon, his sceptre will be in his hand as the one who rows your bark, Ra.
You may mount up to the sky, you are far from the earth, away from wife and kilt."
(spell 267 § 364 a-369)

In the rituals, however, all of the symbols, notions, archetypes and *topoi* constitute real actions and are not conventional motifs, or metaphors, but naturally became so for unbelievers and scholars. Because ancient Egyptian religion is so remote to us there is a danger that it may be analysed as a kind of a fairy-tale or at least, as has already been mentioned, as purely metaphorical. According to The Princeton Handbook of Poetic Terms metaphor is defined as:

"A condensed verbal relation in which an idea, image, or symbol may, by the presence of one or more other ideas, images, or symbols, be enhanced in vividness, complexity, or breadth of implication.

The nature and definition of metaphorical terms and of the relations between them have both been matter for much speculation and disagreement. It is unlikely therefore that a more specific definition will at first be acceptable. The metaphorical relation has been variously described as comparison, contrast, analogy, similarity, juxtaposition, identity, tension, collision, fusion; (...). In recent years the view has gathered weight that metaphor is the radical process in which the internal relationships peculiar to poetry are achieved; some critics maintain that metaphor marks off the poetic mode of vision and utterance from the logical or discursive mode; others, usually on anthropological evidence, argue that all language is metaphorical. The traditional view, however, is that metaphor is a figure of speech, or a family of tropes, involving two (occasionally four) operative terms, and that it is used for adornment, liveliness, elucidation, or agreeable mystification." [8]

The New Princeton Handbook from 1994 adds:

"Metaphor is a trope, or figurative expression, in which a word or phrase is shifted from its normal uses to a context where it evokes new meanings. When the ordinary meaning of a word is at odds with the context, we tend to seek relevant features of the word and the situation that will reveal the intended meaning. *If there is a conceptual or material connection between the word and what it denotes – e.g. using cause for effect ("I read Shakespeare," meaning his works) or part for whole ("give me a hand," meaning physical help) – the figure usually has another name (in these examples, metonymy and synecdoche respectively).* To understand metaphors, one must find meanings not predetermined by language, logic, or experience. In the terminology of traditional rhetoric, these figures are 'tropes of a word', appearing in a literal context; in 'tropes of a sentence,' the entire context is figurative, as in allegory, fable, and (according to some) irony."[9]

According to T. Dobrzyńska, metaphor is a semantic phenomenon arising from a certain context. Metaphorical meaning takes place when a word is incorporated in an extraordinary word connection. Moreover, it is even formulated as a text cohesion violation that keep it at a deep level.[10]

However, if one takes into consideration that the Ancient Egyptians were believers of a religion that manifested itself *inter alia* in such texts as the Pyramid Texts, it turns out that the interpreter of religious text must understand the described situations/pictures at the very starting point as actually happening, though they may seem obscure and strange to them. The pictures/images created in the Pyramid Texts, as well as any other religious texts, in this way constitute reality. The dissimilarity of the world of religion to any other visible – *inter alia* different from elsewhere – word connections has weighty consequences, namely the neutralising of metaphor. Religious texts are constructed on different world predications than those widely known. Consequently, that which in everyday and common life context would form a metaphor in the religious text or even more in the religious realities is a fact.[11]

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[8] A. Preminger, associate editors F.J. Warnke, O.B. Hardison Jr. (eds.), *The Princeton Handbook of Poetic Terms*, Princeton, New Yersey 1986, pp. 136-141.

[9] T.V.F. Brogan (ed.), *The New Princeton Handbook*, Princeton 1994, pp. 184-190.

[10] T. Dobrzyńska, Metafora w baśni (= Metaphor in Fairy Tale), [in:] M.R. Mayenowa, *Semiotyka i struktura tekstu*, Wrocław 1973 (hereinafter referred to as: Dobrzyńska, Metaphor), p. 171 and references therein.

[11] Contrary to the analyses by S.A.B. Mercer, *Literary Criticism of the Pyramid Texts*, London 1956 and O. Firchow, *Grundzüge der Stilistik in den altägyptischen Pyramidentexten*, Berlin 1953. Compare, however, the analoguous situation noted and described by T. Dobrzyńska as far as fairy-stories are concerned: Dobrzyńska, Metaphor, pp. 171-188, eadem, Metafora czy baśń? O interpretacji semantycznej utworów poetyckich (= Metaphor or Fairy-Story? On Semantic Interpretation of Poetic Composition), *Pamiętnik Literacki* LXV (1874), part 1, pp. 107-122.

Events and actions are described as happening at the moment of saying the utterance or as those which had *just* occurred by means of creative and causative power. However, it may be assumed that this does not necessarily mean that the texts were read during particular rituals. Certainly some of them actually were, although maybe only during the funeral, but the present author will not attempt in this work to make any firm statements about this problem that is widely discussed in the literature.[12] This specific problem demands mentioning, but cannot be solved at this stage of research. More significant, however, seem to be the act of pronouncing the words to create the reality indispensable for the king's revival and his existence in the Beyond. If it is written about the pharaoh or if he actually says about himself that:

§ 365a *sḳ.t n.f t3 rdw r pt pr.f jm r pt*
§ 365b *prr.f ḥr ḥtj n jdt wrt*
§ 366a *j.p3 NN pn m 3pd ḫnn.f m ḫprr*
§ 366b *j.p3.f m 3pd ḫnn.f m ḫprr*
§ 366c *m nst šwt jmt wj3.k rˁ*

"A stairway to the sky is set up for him that he may mount upon it to the sky – and he will ascend on the smoke of the great censing.
This King will fly up as a bird and alight as a beetle – he does flies up as a bird and alights as a beetle on the empty throne which is in your bark, o Ra."
(spell 267 § 365 a-366 c)

This does not mean that one is dealing only with a picturesque, imaginary, namely metaphorical, description of the King's death or this happened to his soul after death, it means though that in certain moments he is reaching the sky, literally, by climbing the stairs, but also in some other conditions, however, he ascends to heaven on the 'smoke of the great censing'. Next, to accomplish the task and to reach his destination the pharaoh becomes a bird and/or a beetle, for assuming their form allows him to fulfil what he is predestined to fulfil.

Although they certainly were present, analysing use of metaphors in the writings of ancient religion is not only an extremely difficult task, but also one most often based on guess-work. The appearance of metaphor in a text, as is repeated in the subject literature,[13] is responsible for disturbance in any coherent perception of a text. It is weighty problem, particularly as far as ancient Egyptian religious texts are concerned. The problem of the coherence of the utterance is evident for the translator/interpreter at least because of its outward lack of cohesion, namely characteristic of Egyptian grammar use of e.g. 'virtual relative forms', where in a sentence neither conjunction nor pronoun determines the form employed. That which makes the fragment of a text understandable is its broader context and the above-mentioned so-called "life context", in our case, the complex/compound context of the Pyramid Texts as a whole, as texts being a 'formulation' of ancient Egyptian beliefs in those times.

[12] See J. Popielska-Grzybowska, *The Pyramid Texts as a Source of Topoi in the Coffin Texts* (unpublished PhD thesis, in preparation for publishing): introduction pp. 13-14 footnotes 34, 35.

[13] Cf. works of Professor Teresa Dobrzyńska in the bibliography and see footnotes above. To name only the most eminent ones: T. Dobrzyńska, *Metafora*, Wrocław 1984; eadem, *Tekst. Próba syntezy* (= *Text. Attempt of Synthesis*), Warszawa 1993 (**hereinafter referred to as:** Dobrzyńska, *Text*); eadem, *Mówiąc przenośnie… studia o metaforze* (= *Figuratively Speaking… Studies on Metaphor*), Warszawa 1994.

"Reading someone's else text is not and cannot be mechnical/automatic activity, for the way of interpreting determines the functional perspective of individual elements of speech judging beforehand about the communication content of the whole."[14]

The present author is convinced that every particular spell was very carefully composed, in a mature way, even though at first reading it may seem incoherent.

As for instance in spell 577:

§ 1520a *ḫ ʿ wsjr wʿb sḫm ḳ3 nb m3ʿt*
§ 1520b *r tpj rnpt nb rnpt*
§ 1521a *ḥtp tm ḥtp nṯrw ḥtp šw ḥnʿ tfnt ḥtp gbb ḥnʿ nwt*
§ 1521b *ḥtp wsjr ḥnʿ jst ḥtp stš ḥnʿ nt*
§ 1522a *ḥtp nṯrw nb jmw pt ḥtp nṯrw nb jmw t3 jmw mw*
§ 1522b *ḥtp nṯrw nb rsw mḥtjw ḥtp nṯrw nb jmntjw j3btjw*
§ 1522c *ḥtp nṯrw nb sp3tjw ḥtp nṯrw nb nwtjw*
§ 1523a *ḥr mdw pn wr ʿ3j pr m r n ḏḥwtj n wsjr*
§ 1523b *sḏ3w ʿnḫ ḫtm nṯrw*
§ 1523c *jnpw jp jbw jp.f wsjr NN m ʿ nṯrw jrw t3 n nṯrw jmw pt*
§ 1524a *nb jrp m w3ḫ*
§ 1524b *jp.n sw rnpt.f sḫ3.n sw nww.f*
§ 1524c *jp NN jn rnpt.f ḥnʿ.f*
§ 1524d *sḫ3.n sw nww.f ḥnʿ.f*
§ 1525 *j nwjj jn tm j n.n jn.sn jn nṯrw jr.k wsjr*
§ 1526a *j sn.n smsw tp n jt.f wtwtj n mjwt.f*
§ 1526b *jn.sn jn nṯrw*
§ 1527a *jwr.n sw pt ms.n sw dw3t*
§ 1527b *jwr NN pn ḥnʿ.f jn pt*
§ 1527c *msjw NN pn ḥnʿ.f jn dw3t*
§ 1528a *rmn.k pt m gs.k jmnt ḫr ʿnḫ*
§ 1528b *ʿnḫ.k n ḥn nṯrw ʿnḫ.k*
§ 1528c *rmn NN pt m gs.f jmnt ḫr ʿnḫ*
§ 1528d *ʿnḫ.f ʿnḫ.f n ḥn nṯrw ʿnḫ.f*
§ 1529a *tw3.k t3 m gs.k j3b ḫr w3s*
§ 1529b *ʿnḫ.k ʿnḫ.k n ḥn nṯrw ʿnḫ.k*
§ 1529c *tw3 NN pt m gs.f j3b ḫr ʿnḫ*
§ 1529d *ʿnḫ.f ʿnḫ.f n ḥn nṯrw ʿnḫ.f*
§ 1530a *pr.n NN pn m gs j3b n pt*
§ 1530b *h3w.f m 3pd w3ḏ*
§ 1530c *h3 r[illegible].f nb šjw d3tjw*
§ 1530d *wʿb.n NN pn m šjw smn*

Osiris has appeared, the sceptre has been pure, the Lord of *m3ʿt* has become exalted at the first of the year – the Lord of the Year.
Content is Atum, father of the gods;
Content are Shu and Tefnut;
Content are Geb and Nut;
Contentare Osiris and [Isis];
Content are Seth and Neith;
Content are all the gods in the sky;
Content are all the gods on the earth and in the water:

[14] Dobrzyńska, *Text*, p. 16.

Content are all the southern and northern gods;
Content are all the western and eastern gods;
Content are all the gods of the nomes;
Content are all the gods of the towns
With this great and mighty word
Which has issued from the mouth of Thoth for Osiris – the Treasurer of Life, the Seal-bearer of the gods.
Anubis who claims hearts, he claims Osiris the King from the gods on the earth for the gods in the sky.
The Lord of wine is in opulence, his year has recognised him, his times have remembered him, and the King has been recognised by his year with him, his times with him have remembered him with him.
'Here comes the Dweller of the Abyss', says Atum. 'We have come', say they, say they gods to you, Osiris.
'Here comes the oldest brother, the first-born of his father, the eldest of his mother', say they – say the gods.
The sky conceived him, the morning star bore him, and this King has been conceived with him by the sky, this King is born with him by the morning star.
You support the sky with your western side – possessing life, and you live because the gods order that you live. (Consequently) the King supports the sky with his western side – possessing life, and he lives and he will live because the gods order that he live.
You sustain the earth with your eastern side – possessing sovereignty, and you live and you will live because the gods order that you live. (Consequently) the King, sustains the earth with his eastern side – possessing life, and he lives and he will live because the gods order that he live.
The King has gone up from the eastern side of the sky, he shall descend as green duck. The Lord of the Lakes of the Netherworld has descended to him, and this King has bathed in the Goose-lakes."

One can, however, easily notice the introduction into the action taking place with the first lines, then we have confirmation and progress of the situation shown in part, which could be interpreted as litany, especially given that one can without some effort point at its parts, but also it is possible to treat it as a kind of **repetition**, namely **anaphora,** especially that the repetitions are closed with one or even more **enumerations**, rhetoric figure used to name things and describe them/their state.

The analysis, as well as the examination of some *topoi*, which appear in certain genres of utterances in the Pyramid Texts, recurrently form the so-called 'leitmotives', for example *topos of life and death of the pharaoh* or another *topos of completeness* corroborated together one with the other – that is, inextricably linked. Both strongly incorporated in the whole cultural, religious context of the Pyramid Texts or the Coffin Texts – for the believers constituting reality, true acts and states – not metaphorical ones.